

BREAK INTO AEROSPACE

Historic & Innovative Aircraft

Comprehensive Chronological Directory

Targeted for the 2025–2026 Reference Cycle

What This Document Covers: Listed below are some of 100 most relevant aircraft that have shaped the history of aviation. The airplanes are ordered chronologically, with main traits that advanced the industry. Included are aircraft from all around the globe, from general aviation to commercial and military aircraft. This list was elaborated on the basis of impactful innovative aircraft in history. Use the description to get a first impression of their characteristics, and apply what you learned during the course to understand their aerodynamics, engines and capabilities.

AIRCRAFT DIRECTORY

Wright Flyer: The first successful powered aircraft, marking the birth of aviation.	1903
Blériot XI: The first aircraft to cross the English Channel, demonstrating the potential of flight.	1909
Fokker Eindecker: The first fighter aircraft with synchronized machine guns, revolutionizing aerial combat.	1915
Curtiss JN4 “Jenny”: Widely used American trainer and barnstorming aircraft.	1915
Junkers J 1: The world’s first all-metal aircraft, pioneering metal construction.	1915
Sopwith Camel: Iconic British WWI fighter known for its agility and success rate.	1917
Fokker Dr.I: German triplane flown by the Red Baron, symbolizing WWI aviation prowess.	1917
Vickers Vimy: Used in the first nonstop transatlantic flight by Alcock and Brown in 1919.	1917

Ford Trimotor: Early successful commercial airliner, advancing passenger air travel.

1926

Spirit of St. Louis: Charles Lindbergh's aircraft for the first solo transatlantic flight.

1927

Lockheed Vega: Used by Amelia Earhart for her solo Atlantic crossing.

1927

Junkers Ju 52: German transport aircraft significant in both civil and military roles.

1931

Douglas DC3: Revolutionized air transport with reliability and efficiency.

1935

Hawker Hurricane: Key British fighter alongside the Spitfire during WWII.

1935

Boeing B17 Flying Fortress: Heavy bomber used extensively in daylight bombing raids over Europe.

1935

Supermarine Spitfire: Iconic British WWII fighter known for its role in the Battle of Britain.

1936

Messerschmitt Bf 109: Main German WWII fighter, produced in large numbers.

1937

Beechcraft Model 18: Twin engine utility aircraft.

1937

Short Sunderland: British WWII flying boat patrol bomber.

1937

Piper J3 Cub: Popular light aircraft important in training and recreational flying.

1938

Mitsubishi A6M Zero: Japanese carrier-based fighter, dominant in early WWII.

1939

Lockheed P38 Lightning: American WWII fighter with distinctive twin booms.

1939

North American P51 Mustang: American long-range fighter escorting bombers over Europe.

1940

De Havilland Mosquito: British multirole aircraft made primarily of wood.

1940

Avro Lancaster: British heavy bomber famous for the Dambusters raid.

1941

Boeing B29 Superfortress: Advanced bomber that dropped atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki.

1942

Yakovlev Yak9: Soviet WWII fighter aircraft.

1942

Messerschmitt Me 262: First operational jet-powered fighter.

1944

Lockheed P80 Shooting Star: First operational jet fighter used by the U.S. Air Force.

1945

Bell X1: First aircraft to break the sound barrier, piloted by Chuck Yeager.

1946

MikoyanGurevich MiG15: Soviet jet fighter used in the Korean War.

1947

North American F86 Sabre: U.S. jet fighter countering the MiG15 in Korea.

1947

Beechcraft Bonanza: General aviation aircraft with the longest production run.

1947

Antonov An2: Massive biplane utility aircraft.

1947

De Havilland Canada DHC2 Beaver: STOL utility aircraft.

1947

De Havilland Comet: World's first commercial jet airliner.

1949

Boeing B52 Stratofortress: Long-range strategic bomber still in service today.

1952

Lockheed C130 Hercules: Versatile military transport aircraft used worldwide.

1954

Douglas A4 Skyhawk: Carrier-capable attack aircraft.

1954

Cessna 172 Skyhawk: Most produced aircraft in history, staple of general aviation.

1955

Lockheed U2: High-altitude reconnaissance aircraft used during the Cold War.

1955

Fokker F27 Friendship: Successful turboprop airliner.

1955

Dassault Mirage III: French jet fighter that saw extensive use and export.

1956

Boeing KC135 Stratotanker: Aerial refueling tanker.

1956

Boeing 707: Popularized jet air travel and set standards for airliners.

1958

Douglas DC8: Early jet airliner competing with the Boeing 707.

1958

McDonnell Douglas F4 Phantom II: Multirole fighter used extensively in Vietnam.

1958

North American X15: Rocket-powered research aircraft reaching the edge of space.

1959

Mikoyan MiG21: Supersonic jet fighter used by numerous countries.

1959

Northrop F5 Freedom Fighter: Lightweight supersonic fighter.

1959

Piper PA28 Cherokee: Popular family of light aircraft.

1960

Grumman A6 Intruder: All-weather attack aircraft.

1960

Lockheed SR71 Blackbird: Fastest airbreathing manned aircraft, used for reconnaissance.

1964

Beechcraft King Air: Popular twin-turboprop utility aircraft.

1964

De Havilland Canada DHC6 Twin Otter: STOL utility aircraft.

1965

Hawker Siddeley Harrier: First operational V/STOL aircraft.

1967

Boeing 737: Bestselling commercial jetliner.

1967

Embraer EMB 110 Bandeirante: Brazilian turboprop transport.

1968

Tupolev Tu144: Soviet supersonic transport aircraft.

1968

Lockheed C5 Galaxy: Large military transport aircraft.

1968

Boeing 747: The first widebody airliner, known as the “Queen of the Skies.”

1969

Concorde: Supersonic passenger airliner, a marvel of engineering.

1969

Grumman F14 Tomcat: U.S. Navy fighter with variable-sweep wings.

1970

McDonnell Douglas F15 Eagle: Highly successful air superiority fighter.

1972

Airbus A300: First twin-engine widebody airliner.

1972

Fairchild Republic A10 Thunderbolt II: Close air support aircraft known as the “Warthog.”

1972

Cessna Citation series: Family of business jets.

1972

General Dynamics F16 Fighting Falcon: Widely used multirole fighter aircraft.

1974

Boeing B1 Lancer: Supersonic strategic bomber.

1974

Panavia Tornado: Multirole combat aircraft developed by the UK, Germany, and Italy.

1974

Sukhoi Su25: Russian close air support aircraft.

1975

Sukhoi Su27: Soviet/Russian air superiority fighter with impressive capabilities.

1977

Mikoyan MiG29: Soviet fighter aircraft designed to counter U.S. fighters.

1977

McDonnell Douglas F/A18 Hornet: Carrier-capable multirole fighter.

1978

Embraer EMB 312 Tucano: Trainer and light attack aircraft.

1980

Lockheed F117 Nighthawk: First operational stealth aircraft.

1981

Antonov An124 Ruslan: Large Soviet military transport aircraft.

1982

Cessna 208 Caravan: Versatile utility aircraft.

1982

Harbin Y12: Chinese utility aircraft.

1982

Bombardier Dash 8: Turboprop regional airliner.

1983

Dassault Rafale: French multirole fighter with advanced avionics.

1986

Airbus A320: First airliner with digital fly-by-wire controls.

1987

Antonov An225 Mriya: World's largest cargo aircraft.

1988

Saab JAS 39 Gripen: Swedish multirole fighter with advanced technology.

1988

Northrop Grumman B2 Spirit: Stealth bomber with flying wing design.

1989

Pilatus PC12: Swiss single-engine turboprop aircraft.

1991

Bombardier CRJ Series: Regional jet airliners.

1991

Eurofighter Typhoon: Advanced European multirole fighter.

1994

Boeing 777: Long-range widebody airliner.

1994

Lockheed Martin F22 Raptor: Advanced stealth air superiority fighter.

1997

Embraer EJet family: Successful regional jetliners from Brazil.

2001

HAL Tejas: Indian multi-role combat aircraft.

2001

Gulfstream G550: Long-range business jet.

2003

Airbus A380: World's largest passenger airliner.

2005

Lockheed Martin F35 Lightning II: Modern stealth multirole fighter.

2006

Boeing 787 Dreamliner: Advanced composite airliner with improved fuel efficiency.

2009

Sukhoi Su57: Russian fifth-generation stealth fighter.

2010

Northrop Grumman X47B: Unmanned combat aerial vehicle.

2011

Airbus A350: Long-range, widebody airliner with advanced technology.

2013

Comac C919: Chinese narrow-body airliner.

2015

SUMMARY REFERENCE TABLE

#	Aircraft Platform	Historical Year
1	Wright Flyer — Birth of Powered Flight	1903
2	Blériot XI — English Channel Crossing Milestone	1909
3	Fokker Eindecker — Synchronized Aerial Combat Weaponry	1915
4	Curtiss JN4 “Jenny” — Prolific American Flight Trainer	1915
5	Junkers J 1 — Pioneering All-Metal Airframe Construction	1915
6	Sopwith Camel — Highly Agile WWI Fighter Platform	1917
7	Fokker Dr.I — Renowned Triplane Interceptor	1917
8	Vickers Vimy — First Nonstop Transatlantic Flight	1917
9	Ford Trimotor — Early Commercial Passenger Evolution	1926
10	Spirit of St. Louis — Solo Transatlantic Flight Anchor	1927
11	Lockheed Vega — Landmark Solo Oceanic Crossings	1927
12	Junkers Ju 52 — Dual-Role Multi-Mission Transport	1931
13	Douglas DC3 — Commercial Air Transport Transformation	1935
14	Hawker Hurricane — Critical Defensive WWII Airframe	1935
15	Boeing B17 Flying Fortress — Heavy Daytime Strategic Bomber	1935
16	Supermarine Spitfire — Legendary Battle of Britain Fighter	1936
17	Messerschmitt Bf 109 — High-Volume Tactical WWII Interceptor	1937
18	Beechcraft Model 18 — Twin-Engine Utility Configuration	1937
19	Short Sunderland — Long-Range Flying Boat Patrol Bomber	1937
20	Piper J3 Cub — Definitive Light Civil Flight Trainer	1938
21	Mitsubishi A6M Zero — Dominant Carrier-Based Air Superiority	1939
22	Lockheed P38 Lightning — Specialized Twin-Boom Interceptor	1939
23	North American P51 Mustang — Long-Range Bomber Escort	1940
24	De Havilland Mosquito — Composite Multi-Role Airframe	1940
25	Avro Lancaster — Strategic Heavy Bomber Platform	1941
26	Boeing B29 Superfortress — High-Altitude Atomic Mission Asset	1942
27	Yakovlev Yak9 — Soviet Tactical Frontline Fighter	1942
28	Messerschmitt Me 262 — First Operational Jet-Powered Fighter	1944
29	Lockheed P80 Shooting Star — Early U.S. Air Force Tactical Jet	1945
30	Bell X1 — Supersonic Speed Barrier Breakthrough	1946
31	MikoyanGurevich MiG15 — Early Swept-Wing Soviet Jet Engine Interceptor	1947
32	North American F86 Sabre — High-Transonic Air Superiority Fighter	1947
33	Beechcraft Bonanza — Long-Running Production General Aviation Staple	1947
34	Antonov An2 — Large-Scale Utility Biplane Architecture	1947
35	De Havilland Canada DHC2 Beaver — High-Utility Bush STOL Design	1947

#	Aircraft Platform	Historical Year
36	De Havilland Comet — World's First Commercial Jet Airliner	1949
37	Boeing B52 Stratofortress — Long-Endurance Strategic Heavy Bomber	1952
38	Lockheed C130 Hercules — Multi-Mission Tactical Military Airlift	1954
39	Douglas A4 Skyhawk — Carrier-Capable Lightweight Attack Aircraft	1954
40	Cessna 172 Skyhawk — Most Produced General Aviation Aircraft	1955
41	Lockheed U2 — High-Altitude Cold War Reconnaissance Platform	1955
42	Fokker F27 Friendship — High-Volume Regional Turboprop Airliner	1955
43	Dassault Mirage III — High-Export Delta-Wing Mach 2 Fighter	1956
44	Boeing KC135 Stratotanker — Dedicated Strategic Aerial Refueling Asset	1956
45	Boeing 707 — Jet Air Travel Standardizer	1958
46	Douglas DC8 — Early Intercontinental Commercial Jetliner	1958
47	McDonnell Douglas F4 Phantom II — Supersonic All-Weather Multirole Fighter	1958
48	North American X15 — Hypersonic Sub-Orbital Rocket Research Vehicle	1959
49	Mikoyan MiG21 — Prolific Supersonic Tactical Interceptor	1959
50	Northrop F5 Freedom Fighter — Low-Cost Lightweight Supersonic Fighter	1959
51	Piper PA28 Cherokee — General Aviation Training & Family Utility	1960
52	Grumman A6 Intruder — Mid-Wing All-Weather Carrier Strike Variant	1960
53	Lockheed SR71 Blackbird — High-Mach Airbreathing Strategic Reconnaissance	1964
54	Beechcraft King Air — Definitive Corporate Twin-Turboprop Utility	1964
55	De Havilland Canada DHC6 Twin Otter — Short Takeoff Regional Transport	1965
56	Hawker Siddeley Harrier — First Operational V/STOL Tactical Strike	1967
57	Boeing 737 — Globally Bestselling Short-to-Medium-Haul Commercial Jet	1967
58	Embraer EMB 110 Bandeirante — Early Brazilian Turboprop Evolution	1968
59	Tupolev Tu144 — Early Soviet Supersonic Civil Transport	1968
60	Lockheed C5 Galaxy — Heavy Strategic Intercontinental Military Airlift	1968
61	Boeing 747 — Iconic Widebody Variant (Queen of the Skies)	1969
62	Concorde — Supersonic Civil Transport Engineering Marvel	1969
63	Grumman F14 Tomcat — Carrier-Based Variable-Sweep Fleet Interceptor	1970
64	McDonnell Douglas F15 Eagle — High-Success Air Superiority Platform	1972
65	Airbus A300 — First Twin-Engine Commercial Widebody	1972
66	Fairchild Republic A10 Thunderbolt II — High-Survivability Close Air Support	1972
67	Cessna Citation series — Prolific Corporate Business Jet Architecture	1972
68	General Dynamics F16 Fighting Falcon — Fly-By-Wire Multirole Strike Fighter	1974
69	Boeing B1 Lancer — Low-Altitude Supersonic Strategic Bomber	1974
70	Panavia Tornado — Tri-National Variable-Geometry Combat Aircraft	1974

#	Aircraft Platform	Historical Year
71	Sukhoi Su25 — Heavy Frontline Ground Attack Vehicle	1975
72	Sukhoi Su27 — High-Manoeuvrability Long-Range Air Superiority	1977
73	Mikoyan MiG29 — Dual-Engine Counter-Air Tactical Interceptor	1977
74	McDonnell Douglas F/A18 Hornet — Multirole Carrier Strike Platform	1978
75	Embraer EMB 312 Tucano — Basic Military Trainer & Light Attack	1980
76	Lockheed F117 Nighthawk — World's First Operational Stealth Platform	1981
77	Antonov An124 Ruslan — Heavy Strategic Cargo Transport Design	1982
78	Cessna 208 Caravan — Rugged High-Wing Single-Turboprop Utility	1982
79	Harbin Y12 — Chinese Twin-Turboprop Commuter	1982
80	Bombardier Dash 8 — High-Efficiency Short-Haul Regional Turboprop	1983
81	Dassault Rafale — Omnirole Carrier & Land Tactical Combat Platform	1986
82	Airbus A320 — First Commercial Digital Fly-By-Wire Airliner	1987
83	Antonov An225 Mriya — World's Largest Heavy Cargo Transport Air-frame	1988
84	Saab JAS 39 Gripen — Integrated Digital Delta-Canard Multirole Fighter	1988
85	Northrop Grumman B2 Spirit — Flying-Wing Low-Observable Stealth Bomber	1989
86	Pilatus PC12 — High-Utility Single-Engine Corporate Turboprop	1991
87	Bombardier CRJ Series — Pioneer of Modern Regional Jet Markets	1991
88	Eurofighter Typhoon — Advanced Canard Delta Swing-Role Combat Asset	1994
89	Boeing 777 — First Fly-By-Wire Long-Range Commercial Widebody	1994
90	Lockheed Martin F22 Raptor — Fifth-Generation Stealth Air Dominance Platform	1997
91	Embraer EJet family — Prolific Regional Airliners	2001
92	HAL Tejas — Indian Light Fly-By-Wire Multirole Combat Airframe	2001
93	Gulfstream G550 — Ultra-Long-Range Intercontinental Business Transport	2003
94	Airbus A380 — Double-Deck High-Capacity Commercial Passenger Widebody	2005
95	Lockheed Martin F35 Lightning II — Joint Strike Stealth Multirole Platform	2006
96	Boeing 787 Dreamliner — Fully Integrated Composite Commercial Widebody	2009
97	Sukhoi Su57 — Russian Fifth-Generation Internal Weapons Bay Stealth Fighter	2010
98	Northrop Grumman X47B — Low-Observable Carrier-Capable UCAV Platform	2011
99	Airbus A350 — Carbon-Composite Extended Range Intercontinental Widebody	2013
100	Comac C919 — Chinese Domestic Mainline Narrowbody Contender	2015

THE STRUCTURAL REALITY OF AEROSPACE MILESTONES

The evolution of global aircraft platform development represents a continuous technical timeline where changes in aerodynamics, structural materials, power electronic architectures, and thermodynamic propulsion systems directly dictate structural transport viability. Every milestone in this directory corresponds to a quantitative shift across the engineering bounds of aviation history.

From the early wood-and-fabric mechanics of low-speed flyers to modern low-observable flying wings and fully composite intercontinental airliners utilizing digital fly-by-wire controls, the progress of aerospace engineering remains bound by hard physical constraints. Sizing propulsion envelopes, managing aeroelastic structural coupling, optimizing thrust-to-power weight coefficients, and meeting rigid airworthiness type certification benchmarks are the load-bearing requirements that define these platforms, serving as the benchmark foundation for the modern global aviation ecosystem.

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